

# Massachusetts Cultural Resource Information System

## Scanned Record Cover Page

|                                |                                                                                                    |
|--------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Inventory No:</b>           | WHI.305                                                                                            |
| <b>Historic Name:</b>          | Gurney, Daniel and Deborah<br>Ramsdell House                                                       |
| <b>Common Name:</b>            | Pleasant View Dairy                                                                                |
| <b>Address:</b>                | 471-475 Plymouth St                                                                                |
| <b>City/Town:</b>              | Whitman                                                                                            |
| <b>Village/Neighborhood:</b>   |                                                                                                    |
| <b>Local No:</b>               |                                                                                                    |
| <b>Year Constructed:</b>       | C 1791                                                                                             |
| <b>Architectural Style(s):</b> | Federal;                                                                                           |
| <b>Use(s):</b>                 | Agricultural; Boarding House; Dairy; Multiple Family Dwelling House; Single Family Dwelling House; |
| <b>Significance:</b>           | Agriculture; Architecture;                                                                         |
| <b>Area(s):</b>                |                                                                                                    |
| <b>Designation(s):</b>         |                                                                                                    |
| <b>Building Materials:</b>     | Roof: Asphalt Shingle;<br>Wall: Vinyl Siding; Wood;<br>Foundation: Stone, Uncut;                   |
| <b>Demolished</b>              | No                                                                                                 |



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Commonwealth of Massachusetts  
Massachusetts Historical Commission  
220 Morrissey Boulevard, Boston, Massachusetts 02125  
[www.sec.state.ma.us/mhc](http://www.sec.state.ma.us/mhc)

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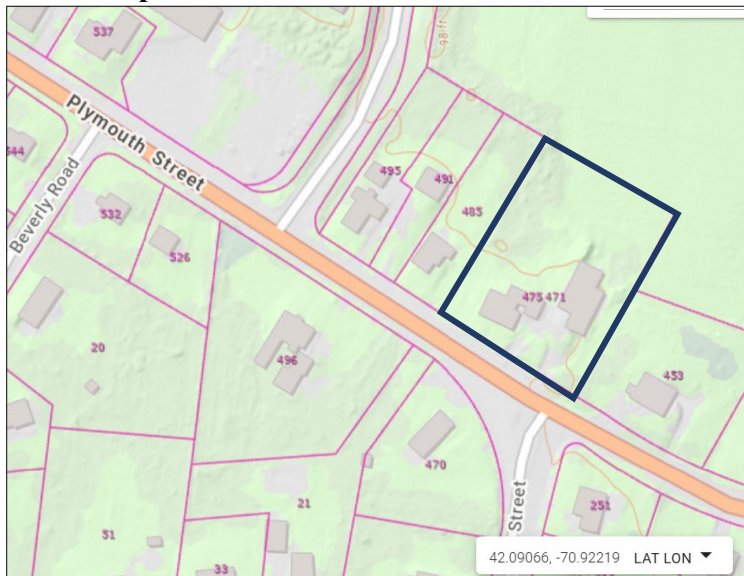
# FORM B – BUILDING

MASSACHUSETTS HISTORICAL COMMISSION  
MASSACHUSETTS ARCHIVES BUILDING  
220 MORRISSEY BOULEVARD  
BOSTON, MASSACHUSETTS 02125

## Photograph



## Locus Map



**Recorded by:** Lynn Smiledge

**Organization:** Whitman Historical Commission

**Date (month/year):** May 2025

Assessor's Number USGS Quad Area(s) Form Number

15-97-2

Whitman

WHI.305  
WHI.306

**Town/City:** Whitman

**Place:** (neighborhood or village):

**Address:** 471-475 Plymouth Street

**Historic Name:** Daniel Gurney House & Barn -Pleasant View Dairy

**Uses:** Present: Multi-family dwelling

Original: Dwelling

**Date of Construction:** Possibly ca. 1791

**Source:** Marriage date

**Style/Form:** Federal Cape

**Architect/Builder:** Unknown

### Exterior Material:

Foundation: Fieldstone

Wall/Trim: Vinyl siding / Vinyl & wood

Roof: Asphalt shingle

### Outbuildings/Secondary Structures:

Barn (late 19<sup>th</sup> c.)

### Major Alterations (with dates):

Enclosed porch (1919-1939)

Vinyl siding

Replacement windows

**Condition:** Fair

**Moved:** no ☒ yes ☐ **Date:**

**Acreage:** 1.11

**Setting:** Moderately densely settled residential neighborhood on the far east side of Whitman. Former farmland developed in the late 19<sup>th</sup> through the early 20<sup>th</sup> centuries for housing to support local industries. Small to moderate-sized dwellings on generous lots with house forms ranging from Capes to Colonial Revival.

RECEIVED

AUG 11 2025

MASS. HIST. COMM.

# INVENTORY FORM B CONTINUATION SHEET

WHITMAN

471-475 PLYMOUTH STREET

MASSACHUSETTS HISTORICAL COMMISSION

220 MORRISSEY BOULEVARD, BOSTON, MASSACHUSETTS 02125

Area(s)

Form No.

WHI.305  
WHI.306

☐ Recommended for listing in the National Register of Historic Places.

*If checked, you must attach a completed National Register Criteria Statement form.*

*Use as much space as necessary to complete the following entries, allowing text to flow onto additional continuation sheets.*

## ARCHITECTURAL DESCRIPTION:

*Describe architectural features. Evaluate the characteristics of this building in terms of other buildings within the community.*

The dwelling at **471-475 Plymouth Street** occupies a 1.11-acre trapezoidal lot on the north side of the street at its intersection with Pleasant Street. The house faces south. The parcel is maintained in patchy grass and includes a portion of cultivated field at its north end. Lone and clustered mature trees dot the perimeter. A paved driveway enters and exits the property from Plymouth Street, circling past a large barn sited off the northeast corner of the dwelling and a porch at its east elevation. The driveway encloses a large grassy island at the street. The large barn, which exceeds the size of the house, is shown on the 1903 map. An additional driveway enters the property from Plymouth Street and ends at a garage addition at the east side of the barn.

This full Cape form house was constructed around 1791. It comprises a one-and-one-half-story, side-gabled, five-bay-by-three-bay main block (the original dwelling) and four dependencies. The dependencies include a full-length, hip-roofed enclosed porch at the east elevation, a one-story ell at the north elevation, and a one-story block extending from the north east corner. The house rises from a fieldstone foundation and is clad in vinyl siding. The roof is surfaced with asphalt shingles and carries a brick chimney centered at the ridge. A second brick chimney rises from the roof ridge of the northeast block.

Trim at the house is limited to narrow corner boards and a shallow frieze board at the façade (south elevation). The centered entry at the main block contains a glass-and-panel-door with a wide surround which appears to conceal early sidelights and perhaps a transom. The door fronts a granite stoop which lands at the lawn. The windows at the main block are uniform in size and contain one-over-one replacement sash framed by narrow molded surrounds at the façade, and both molded and flat surrounds at the side elevations. A four-bay shed dormer occupies the west roof slope and a continuous dormer occupies the east roof slope. The hip-roofed enclosed porch spanning the east elevation is glazed with continuous sliding-glass windows above a knee wall. An entry near the east end fronts a shallow stoop and a paved walkway leading to the driveway.

The northeast block extends east from the junction of the north wall of the main block and the east wall of the ell. It is four bays wide and three bays deep with an entry at the second-most easterly bay. The window openings include one-over-one sash and a sliding-glass window flanking the door.

The large barn (WHI.306) sited off the northeast corner of the house, which is unique and worthy of preservation, comprises a one-and-one-half-story, front-gabled main block with two dependencies. The dependencies include a one-story, front-gabled ell extending east from the façade (south elevation) which incorporates a shed-roofed garage block at the east wall; and a one-story, shed-roofed block spanning the east elevation. The building is clad in a combination of vinyl siding and ship-lap wood clapboards at the façade and wood shingles at the side elevations. It has a granite foundation and an asphalt shingle roof. Openings at the façade of the main block include a tall, arched, barn-board door with a molded surround surmounted by an arched hay door with a molded keystone surround. The hay door is surmounted by a roundel at the gable peak. The arched door opening is flanked by a six-over-six wood window. (See page 3 for additional information about the barn.)

The main block of this dwelling was built in the full Cape form. The Cape Cod house form, a one-story, side-gabled house with a central chimney and steeply-pitched roof, emerged in southeastern New England ca. 1700 and saw continued use through the mid-19<sup>th</sup> century. The full Cape design was one of the later iterations of the house type. Defining characteristics of the Cape style illustrated in this house include the full Cape configuration (five bays with center entry), side-gabled roof, and center chimney. The possible existence of a door surround with sidelights and transom is consistent with the Federal (1780-1820) stylistic period.



471-475 PLYMOUTH STREET

Area(s)      Form No.

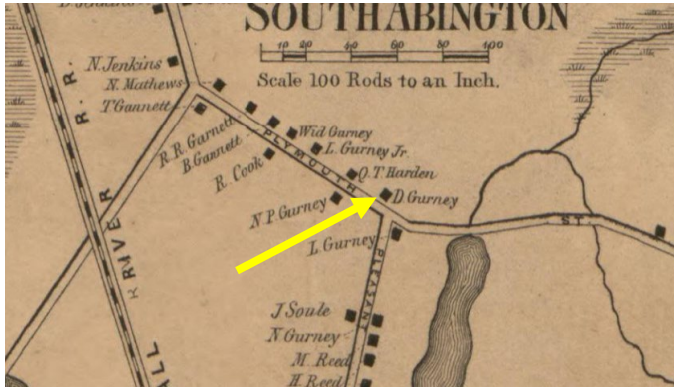
220 MORRISSEY BOULEVARD, BOSTON, MASSACHUSETTS 02125

WHI.305  
WHI.306

## HISTORICAL NARRATIVE

*Discuss the history of the building. Explain its associations with local (or state) history. Include uses of the building, and the role(s) the owners/occupants played within the community.*

The town of Whitman in southeastern Massachusetts, originally settled in the northern part of Bridgewater, became part of the town of Abington in 1712. In 1875 the area separated from Abington and was designated South Abington. In 1886 the citizens changed the name of the town to Whitman after one of its prominent families. Agriculture was the basis of the town's economy during its formative years, but only dairy farming persisted into the 20<sup>th</sup> century. By the early 19<sup>th</sup> century Whitman's economy was primarily driven by the tack making and lumbering industries. The lumber was used for shipbuilding and wooden box manufacturing. The mid-19<sup>th</sup> century saw the establishment of boot and shoe factories and ancillary businesses, which soon dominated the local economy. Other products manufactured in Whitman included coffins, packing boxes, and nails. The town is remembered for its early mustering of troops to serve in the Union Army. Whitman's company was the first in the state to report fully equipped for duty at the outset of the Civil War. The town is also associated with the creation of the Toll House cookie in the 1930s by Ruth Wakefield, the owner of the Toll House Restaurant.



1857 map.



1903 map.

Plymouth Street (MA Route 58) is located in the northeast corner of Whitman and runs roughly north to south between the Abington and Hanson town lines. The historic maps of the town show relatively little change between 1857 and 1903 in this more rural part of Whitman. The 1857 map shows a cluster of dwellings along the northeast side of the road between Pleasant and Essex Streets. These properties were among the farmsteads which provided the livelihood of many of the early residents of the town.

This house appears on the 1857 map with D. [Daniel] Gurney shown as the owner; several other dwellings in the immediate area are also owned by members of the Gurney family. The 1879 map does not include this part of Whitman. The dwelling is labeled B. [Bertrand] W. Atwood on the 1903 map, where it is shown with the large barn which is extant on the property. The earliest recorded conveyance found for the property in a clear chain of ownership was the 1874 sale at auction of a then 50-acre parcel by the estate of Daniel Gurney, Jr. It was purchased by Jacob H. Gurney for \$2,800. This full Cape form house was likely built by Daniel Gurney, Sr. around the time of his marriage to Deborah Ramsdell (1767-1814) in 1791.

Daniel Gurney, Sr. was a farmer. The couple's son Daniel Gurney, Jr. (1796-1871), who was married to Mehitabel Harden (1802-1853) in 1819, likely started in farming but was listed as a shoemaker in the 1850 census. Later censuses report him as a widower with a number of lodgers residing in the house. His son Jacob Harden Gurney (1823-1894), who acquired the property in 1874, also worked in the shoe industry. He was first married to Harriet M. Stetson (1826-1863). Their son Eli Eldon Gurney (1849-1901) inherited the property after the death of Jacob Gurney's second wife, Delia Marie Lakin (1826-1900). Eli Gurney was a machinist. In 1901 the property was sold by his widow to Bertrand W. Atwood.

Bertrand Weston Atwood (1868-1942), a foreman at a box factory, was married to Anne Louise Poole (1869-1963). He and his wife did not appear to live at this address but rather owned a home at 82 Pleasant Street. The Atwoods expanded the house soon after they purchased it, as the northeast addition is shown on the 1903 map. This was likely a rental or investment property for Bertrand Atwood, who sold it in 1919. In 1920 it was purchased by Samuel Terzian.

# INVENTORY FORM B CONTINUATION SHEET

WHITMAN

471-475 PLYMOUTH STREET

## MASSACHUSETTS HISTORICAL COMMISSION

220 MORRISSEY BOULEVARD, BOSTON, MASSACHUSETTS 02125

Area(s)

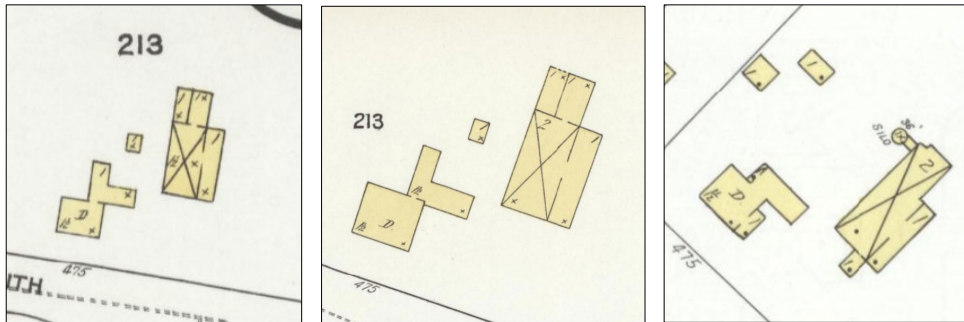
Form No.

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Misak "Samuel" Terzian (1894-1990), who was born in Armenia, came to the United States in 1914. The 1930 census records him living on this property with his wife Arshlooy Tashjian (1899-1973) and operating a dairy farm called the Pleasant View Dairy. A trust was established in 1991 by three of the Terzian children, including Alice Terzian Tavitian (1931-2021), who eventually took ownership of the farm. She was the wife of Garabed "Gary" Tavitian (1932-2023) who emigrated to this country in 1956. The property remains in Tavitian family ownership.

### The Barn (WHI.307)

The Sanborn fire insurance maps below show the evolution of the barn over time. The barn is shown on the 1911 Sanborn map with what appears to be a rear (north) extension to the building seen on the 1903 map. By 1919, the main structure has changed from one-and-one-half stories to two stories. On the 1939 map, the entire main structure is two stories tall, a silo has been added at the rear, and the one-story milk house has been added to the front. These changes reflect the expansion and regulation of the dairy industry in the decades prior. The detached one-story outbuilding on the 1919 map may have been the prior milk house, which regulations at the time required be separate from the barn.



Left to right: 1911, 1919, and 1939 Sanborn maps.

### Title Research

| Date       | Book-Page<br>(Certificate) | Grantor                         | Grantee                         |
|------------|----------------------------|---------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| 08-11-2022 | 57119-317                  | Mark R. Tavitian & Susan Gierej | Mark R. Tavitian                |
| 05-28-2015 | 45944-338                  | Garabed & Alice Tavitian        | Mark R. Tavitian & Susan Gierej |
| 05-28-2015 | 45944-333                  | Alice Tavitian                  | Garabed & Alice Tavitian        |
| 05-28-2015 | 45944-328                  | Alice Tavitian, Trustee         | Alice Tavitian                  |
| 04-24-1991 | 10259-119                  | Alice Tavitian et al.           | Alice Tavitian, Trustee         |
| 02-04-1974 | 3964-439                   | Samuel Terzian                  | Samuel Terzian, Trustee         |
| 01-22-1930 | 1588-94                    | Samuel Terzian et al.           | Samuel Terzian                  |
| 10-29-1920 | 1370-170                   | Charles C. & Annie Ehlert       | Samuel Terzian et al.           |
| 03-20-1919 | 1321-51                    | Bertrand W. Atwood              | Charles C. Ehlert               |
| 12-18-1901 | 839-528                    | Estate of Eli Eldon Gurney      | Bertrand W. Atwood              |
|            |                            | Jacob H. Gurney                 | Eli Eldon Gurney                |
| 04-17-1874 | 405-263                    | Daniel Gurney                   | Jacob H. Gurney                 |

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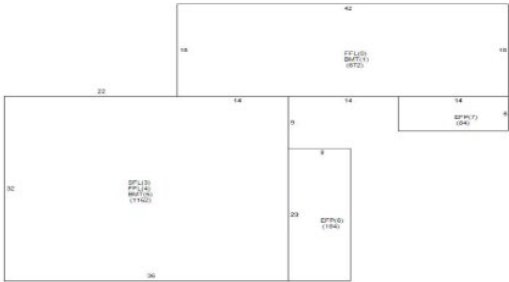
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Assessor's card plan



South (façade) and east elevations.



INVENTORY FORM B CONTINUATION SHEET

WHITMAN

471-475 PLYMOUTH STREET

MASSACHUSETTS HISTORICAL COMMISSION  
220 MORRISSEY BOULEVARD, BOSTON, MASSACHUSETTS 02125

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Barn, west and south (façade) elevations.



Photograph labeled 475 Plymouth St., before 1940. Image courtesy of the Dyer Memorial Library & Archives, Special Collections.